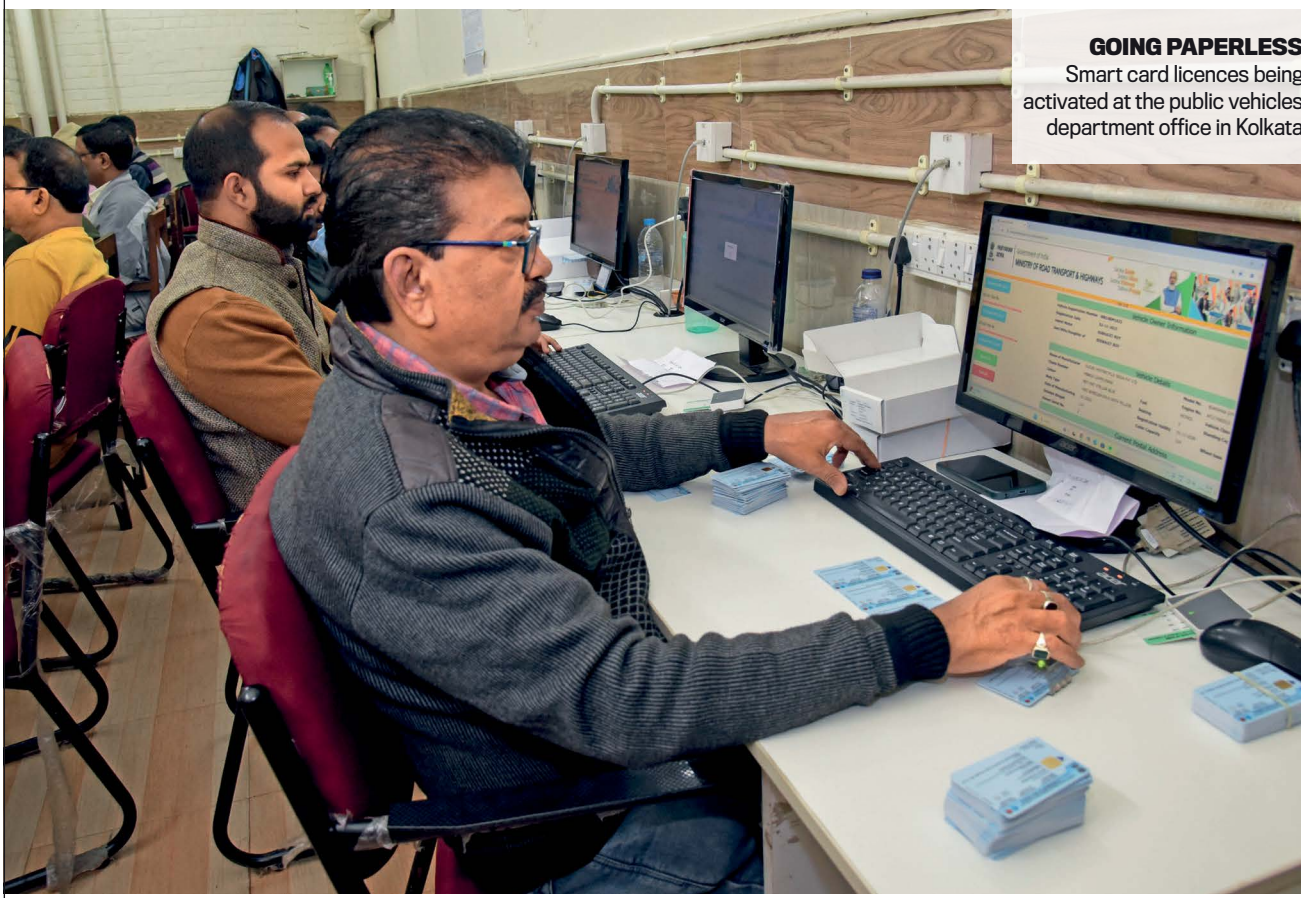


GOING PAPERLESS
Smart card licences being activated at the public vehicles department office in Kolkata

Photographs by DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

THE EASY RIDE

A paperless, largely online system of issuing driving licences has made touts and endless queues history in West Bengal and brought in much-needed convenience and transparency

By ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR

DIGITISATION OF TRANSPORT DEPARTMENT IN WEST BENGAL
Launched in June 2023

Achievement: 1.54 million smart card licences issued till Jan. 14, 2025

THE DRUDGERY

Until recently, obtaining a driving licence in West Bengal was a frustrating ordeal. The state's Regional Transport Offices (RTOs) were synonymous with bureaucratic sluggishness, operating from disorganised and antiquated facilities. For applicants, stepping into this chaotic system felt like entering a labyrinth—one in which touts loomed large. These middlemen thrived on bribes, offering shortcuts through queues, applications and even driving tests—at a steep cost. Then there was the outdated format of the driving licence itself. Issued as fragile paper documents, these